

Gerald Jona Ipapa Etarukot

Georgetown University
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Employment

Postdoctoral Fellow, Georgetown University, 2024–

Education

Ph.D., Economics, University of Delaware, 2024

Committee: Adrienne Lucas (chair), Francisco Costa, Sabrin Beg, Kimberly Oremus

M.S., Economics and Applied Econometrics, University of Delaware, 2021

M.A., International Development, Georgetown University, 2019 (*Thesis of the Year*)

B.S., Mathematics and Statistics, Egerton University, Kenya, 2010

Fields

Primary: Development Economics; Economics of Education; Labor Economics.

Secondary: Energy Economics; Property Rights; Environment and Climate Change.

Peer-Reviewed Publications

- “A Firm of One’s Own: Experimental Evidence on Credit Constraints and Occupational Choice” (with Andrew Brudevold-Newman, Maddalena Honorati, Pamela Jakiela, and Owen Ozier). *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 2024.

Working Papers

- “The Hidden Costs of Recycling: Lead Exposure and Student Learning.” Estimates the causal effect of battery-recycling lead exposure on children’s learning in Kenya using national administrative test data; effects rival the gains from leading school-based interventions.
- “Groundless Claims: Property Rights When Land Ceases to Exist,” 2026. Extends the Besley (1995) framework to climate-driven land loss; calibrated to Kenya’s Rift Valley lakes.

Work in Progress

- “Saturating the Safety Net: Cash Transfers, Skills, and Spillovers in an Urban Refugee Economy” (with Andrew Zeitlin, Billy Jack, and Alex Wendo). Randomized saturation-design RCT, ~4,000 refugee and host households, urban Nairobi; AEA-registered pre-analysis plan. Baseline and three quarterly follow-ups complete; full endline 2026.
- “Property Rights, Climate Displacement, and Household Welfare: Evidence from Kenya’s Rising Lakes.” Tests how tenure status shapes compensation, adaptation, and recovery after slow-onset displacement, combining satellite-derived lake-expansion measures (2005–2025) with a planned household survey.

Other Professional Experience

- Consultant, World Bank, 2018–2020; 2024–
- Research Manager / Coordinator / Associate / Data Analyst, Innovations for Poverty Action (IPA), Kenya, 2010–2017 and 2020. Managed impact-evaluation portfolios (budgets approaching USD 1M) for M. Kremer, E. Miguel, P. Jakiela, O. Ozier, D. Pomeranz, and L. Casaburi.

Research Funding

- IKEA Foundation, RCT (Co-PI): USD 691,000 (2024); USD 92,237 (2025)
- J-PAL King Climate Action Initiative, Research Travel and Project Development Grant (PI), 2022
- IZA/DFID Growth and Labour Markets in Low-Income Countries (GLM-LIC) (Co-PI), 2018

Awards & Honors

- Sally Latham Dissertation Research Award, University of Delaware, 2024
- Sloan/Berkeley Environmental and Energy Economics Fellowship, 2023
- Philadelphia Federal Reserve Mentorship Fellowship, 2023
- University of Delaware Summer Research Fellowship, 2022
- Georgetown University Thesis of the Year, 2019

Presentations

2025: First Annual Research Conference on Global Lead Exposure (Washington, DC)

2023: AERC Senior Policy Seminar XXV (Nairobi); Sloan/Berkeley Graduate Workshop in Environmental and Energy Economics (Berkeley); Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia; AERE Energy, Environment and Transportation Workshop; University of Delaware Economics Seminar

Teaching

- Instructor of record, Development Economics (undergraduate), University of Delaware, 2023–2024
- Graduate Teaching Assistant (Microeconomics, Macroeconomics), University of Delaware, 2019–2022; Georgetown University, 2017–2019

Professional Service

- Referee, *Research in Comparative and International Education*
- Founder and organizer, Graduate Student Research Seminar, University of Delaware
- Founder, AfriKa Policy Students Association, Georgetown University

Skills and Languages

- Software: Stata, R, Python, Julia, MATLAB; SurveyCTO, CsPro, Blaise; Git/GitHub, L^AT_EX, Quarto; large-data management
- Languages: English (fluent), Kiswahili (fluent), Ateso (native), Luhya (basic)

References

- **Owen Ozier**, Associate Professor of Economics, Williams College. oo3@williams.edu
- **Adrienne Lucas**, Professor of Economics, University of Delaware. alucas@udel.edu
- **Andrew Zeitlin**, Professor, Georgetown University. andrew.zeitlin@georgetown.edu

Last updated: June 2026